not mandatory by law.[19] Non-partisanship was achieved because: (i) the speakers had absolute power to command the direction of the legislature; (ii) the USDP had an overwhelming majority; and (iii) ethnic and minor parties allowed themselves to be co-opted by the USDP willingly and chose cooperation rather than confrontation, so they were able to build a certain degree of trust that they were all working for a common goal.[20]

On the other hand, the non-partisan approach had its limits. It made some of the lawmakers lose interest and disengage themselves from their duties. Dissenting party voices were marginalized because of this approach and therefore it was harder for internal factional consultation, especially during communal conflicts where exchange of information was crucial among legislators.

But the legislature was not always non-partisan. When it came to party interest, it was undoubtedly divided. During the debate on the electoral system and the constitutional review, since the NLD and ethnic parties could not challenge the USDP in terms of numbers, some legislators boycotted the debate by taking leave, and some resigned from the electoral system review commission as a sign of protest (Ei Ei Toe Lwin 2014b).

Questions and motions as primary legislative tools

Another common characteristic exhibited from these three conflicts was the extensive use of questions and motions as legislative tools. Consultations within the legislature were not practised, other than in informal discussion during coffee breaks and in the corridors. A public hearing mechanism was activated only in 2015, during the student movement over a new national educational law, and on protection of race and religion bills. This was partly because the Hluttaw was new to this idea and there were no coordinating mechanisms among legislators other than administrative procedures within the legislature.

Moreover, when dealing with the ethnic armed leaders, legislators were hesitant to engage actively because they were perceived to be inferior to other actors and as newcomers to politics, while the former had decades of experience in their roles, and held guns. "No man is above the law but the gun is," a Kayin legislator from the Amyotha Hluttaw told me during my fieldwork in 2014. Furthermore, at the constituency level, legislators received no respect from local authorities, as they had no direct power, though this trend has been diminishing.[21] Therefore, the main weapon of